

Competency Modeling & Performance Framework

Translating organizational priorities into observable performance expectations

Selected Project Materials | Portfolio Edition
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This portfolio edition presents selected excerpts from a larger competency modeling and performance management project completed in partnership with Rock City Enterprises. It is not the complete organizational deliverable.

Project Architecture

A scalable pilot connecting organizational priorities, job expectations, and performance management

Organizational priorities	Core competencies	Food job-family competency	Role-specific competency	Behavioral anchors	Performance evaluation
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Pilot scope

The project established core competencies intended to have organization-wide applicability, then used the food teams as a starting population for more specific job-family and role-level expectations. The pilot spanned Frontline Partner, Team Leader, Manager, and Director roles.

Frontline Partner	Team Leader	Manager	Director
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The intent was not to create four disconnected sets of expectations. The model was designed so organizational expectations could remain consistent while increasing in scope and complexity as responsibility increased.

Co-Creation & Validation Process

The framework was built iteratively with SMEs rather than developed in isolation

1. Preliminary framework	Drafted from organizational mission, values, culture, leadership expectations, job information, and competency-modeling research.
2. SME working sessions	Three groups - C-suite, Directors, and Managers - reviewed, challenged, revised, and reworded competencies in real time.
3. First validation survey	Competencies and essential functions were evaluated after the initial SME sessions.
4. Behavioral anchor development	The project team translated finalized competencies into observable performance expectations across job levels.
5. Second SME round	The same organizational levels reviewed anchor clarity, relevance, scope, accuracy, and performance level.
6. Second validation survey	Behavioral anchors were evaluated for relevance and correct performance tier.

This structure allowed strategic leadership perspectives and operational realities to shape the same framework.

Finalized Competency Architecture

Selected competencies from the pilot model

Important: The descriptions below are condensed portfolio summaries of the finalized competency definitions, not the full definitions from the organizational deliverable. They are included to show the structure and intent of the model while keeping this portfolio sample concise. The complete project contains the full finalized wording for every competency.

Type	Competency	Condensed portfolio summary
Core	Imagination	Fresh ideas and creative solutions; thoughtful process engagement; anticipation of future needs; and new approaches that support guest and partner experiences and long-term success.
Core	Appreciation	Gratitude expressed through recognition, encouragement, and kindness to strengthen relationships, reinforce individual contribution, and foster a positive work environment.
Core	Accountability	Ownership of actions and commitments; reliable follow-through; learning from success and failure; and addressing challenges with honesty and integrity to build trust.
Core	Learning	Curiosity, questions, feedback, growth mindset, and application of learning, with an expectation that employees support both their own development and the development of others.
Core	Communication	Clear and complete information-sharing, active listening, clarification, and respectful, empathetic communication across body language, tone, and writing.
Food job family	Operational Excellence	Consistent safety, cleanliness, product quality, and guest-experience standards, supported by attention to detail, accountability, dependability, and consistency across shifts and locations.
Director	Strategic Leadership	Long-term growth across brands and locations; enterprise-wide strategy balanced with outlet needs, partner well-being, fiscal responsibility, sustainability, and innovation.
Manager	Experience Leadership	Leading teams toward safe, clean, high-quality guest experiences while balancing partner well-being, fiscal responsibility, accountability, development, engagement, and sustainable unit success.
Team Leader	Shift Operations Leadership	Guiding shift execution through standards, real-time coaching, delegation, role modeling, initiative, guest recovery, calm problem solving, teamwork, accountability, and positivity.
Frontline Partner	Guest Service	Fast, friendly, personalized service supported by clear communication, efficient transactions, quality products, and a clean, safe, welcoming environment.

The finalized competencies were developed through in-person SME working sessions where proposed language was revised in real time to reflect organizational culture, operational needs, and job-specific expectations.

Behaviorally Anchored Performance Scale

Turning abstract expectations into observable performance

The model used a five-point rating scale, with behavioral expectations explicitly defined at three milestones. Ratings 2 and 4 were retained as intermediate judgments when performance reflected a mix of adjacent levels.

1	Does Not Meet Expectations	Observable behaviors indicating that performance falls below role requirements.
2	Intermediate	Performance falls between the defined Level 1 and Level 3 anchors.
3	Solid Performer	Observable behaviors representing consistent, successful performance at the current job level.
4	Intermediate	Performance falls between the defined Level 3 and Level 5 anchors.
5	Role Model	Observable behaviors representing performance beyond normal expectations of the current role.

The design goal was to give evaluators concrete reference points while preserving enough flexibility for performance that does not fall neatly into one defined milestone.

Designing for Career Progression

Performance expectations were intentionally scaled across job levels

For competencies spanning multiple levels, the project used a symmetry principle: exceptional performance at one level intentionally begins to resemble successful performance at the next.

Frontline Partner Level 5	→	Team Leader Level 3
Team Leader Level 5	→	Manager Level 3
Manager Level 5	→	Director Level 3

This creates a visible developmental pathway. Advancement is not described only as having more 'leadership potential'; employees and evaluators can see how the scope of expected behavior changes as responsibility increases.

Selected Application Example

Manager-level behavioral expectations

The complete project contains behavioral anchors across all four job levels. This portfolio sample uses the Manager role to demonstrate how competency definitions were translated into performance distinctions.

Experience Leadership	Standards may be inconsistent; accountability issues may be delayed.	Creates a welcoming environment, provides feedback, and balances guest experience with operational needs.	Anticipates needs and builds systems that sustain strong guest experiences.
Accountability	May avoid responsibility or leave teams uncertain.	Demonstrates ownership, anticipates team needs, and models integrity and professionalism.	Coaches proactive planning and inspires accountability across broader team functions.
Communication	May provide unclear information or avoid direct feedback.	Communicates expectations clearly and maintains open, transparent dialogue.	Sustains transparency across shifts/units and serves as a trusted communication resource.

These excerpts are condensed for portfolio presentation and do not reproduce the full behavioral-anchor tables delivered in the original project.

Supporting Consistent Evaluation

The project extended beyond competency definitions and rating anchors

Evaluation forms	Forms connected competency definitions and behavioral anchors to performance assessment.
Behavior-focused notes	Evaluators were guided to document specific, observable actions rather than impressions or personality judgments.
Rating-error awareness	Training guidance addressed halo, horns, leniency, severity, central tendency, similarity, recency, and contrast effects.
Calibration	Leaders were encouraged to compare interpretations and use the anchors as the shared standard rather than comparing employees to one another.
Scenario practice	Practice activities asked evaluators to observe workplace behavior, document evidence, map behavior to competencies, and compare ratings.

Evaluator question: What behaviors have I actually observed, and how do they compare with the expectations defined for this role?

Evaluator Tool Example

Moving from impressions to evidence

"Good worker"	The specific behavior that demonstrated performance and the competency it reflects.
"Seems lazy"	What was observed or heard, without adding an assumption about motivation.
"Always late"	A specific attendance observation with relevant date/context.
Comparing one employee to another	Compare observed behavior with the defined competency anchor.

The project recommended objective, specific notes tied to observable behavior and competency language. This supports more meaningful feedback, stronger calibration, and greater consistency across evaluators.

Evaluator Training Example

Scenario-based practice using competencies and anchors

A proposed evaluator-training activity uses realistic workplace scenarios so leaders can practice applying the framework before using it in formal performance conversations.

Watch a workplace interaction and focus on what actually occurs.	Capture specific behaviors rather than interpretations.	Connect evidence to the relevant competency.	Compare behavior with the defined anchor level.	Discuss rating differences and return to the behavioral standard.

Sample scenario from the project: observe an employee managing an unexpected guest rush while supporting a newer teammate. Evaluators would document how the employee organizes work, communicates under pressure, and maintains service quality, then connect those observations to the appropriate competencies and performance levels.

Organizational Application & Reflection

What carried forward - and what I would strengthen in a future engagement

Organizational application

The original competency labels were not adopted wholesale. After Rock City Enterprises completed additional work on its mission and organizational values, the HR Director used those newly established values as the core competencies while applying the behaviorally anchored performance approach informed by this project.

The most meaningful contribution was the framework itself: define expectations behaviorally, distinguish performance levels, and give leaders observable standards against which to evaluate performance.

What I would do differently

With additional time, I would begin with a fuller discovery phase before developing preliminary competencies. I would interview organizational leaders specifically about the future direction of the business, evolving workforce needs, and capabilities they believed would become increasingly important. That would create a stronger strategic baseline before entering the co-creation process.

I would also plan implementation and training alongside framework development from the beginning. A complete rollout would include evaluator training on behavioral anchors, evidence-based documentation, rating errors, and calibration across leaders and teams.

Portfolio scope: This PDF is a curated sample. The complete organizational deliverable included the full competency-development process, validation data, behavioral anchors across job levels, evaluation forms, and implementation/evaluator-training guidance.